

toured regularly between 1856 and 1886. A trip to the US in 1872 secured Strauss's international fame, and a significant fortune.

In addition to writing dance music, Strauss composed 16 operettas, *The Gypsy Baron* and *Die Fledermaus* outstanding among them. Although the latter's "Champagne Song" drew criticism after the collapse of Vienna's stock market, its hugely uplifting party spirit and rousing beat guaranteed the work's lasting appeal.

In his dances, the commercially astute composer celebrated events such as the opening of buildings, royal occasions, the launch of technologies, and international exhibitions. Many of his finest pieces (including the *Tritsch-Tratsch-Polka*, the *Egyptian March*, and, with his brother Josef, the *Pizzicato-Polka*) were written for the summer seasons that he conducted from 1856 to 1865 at the Vauxhall Pavilion at Pavlovsk.

From 1887, Strauss's third wife rekindled the composer's creative fire after his divorce from actress Angelika Dittrich. In the decade before his death in 1899, works such as *A Night in Venice* and the *Emperor Waltz* were added to his list of enduring hits.